

[Logo: Hackles]

Concepts Lab

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-in-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hackles • Cybersecurity Concepts Lab for Teachers

Demo 8: Social Engineering Defense (Hang Up, Look Up, Call Back)

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell

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Status: DRAFT for teacher, counselor and legal review. Items marked [VERIFY] need checking against a primary source before publication.

AT A GLANCE

Big idea	Social engineering attacks people, not computers. The defense is a calm routine: slow down, verify through a channel you already trust, and use a pre-agreed family code word for urgent requests.
Grade bands	K-2 (the "grown-up check" rule), 3-5 (full role-play cards), 6-8 (full + code word design), 9-12 (full + pretexting, physical and AI-era variants, organizational controls)
CSTA-style concepts	Networks and the Internet (cybersecurity), Impacts of Computing (safety, ethics) (codes: see Concepts Lab Index, Part 4 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05])
Time	15-minute and 45-minute versions
Cost and tech	Printed scenario cards, scorecards, index cards for code word design. No devices.
Teachers do it first	Yes. Part A about 25 minutes.

MAKE IT STICK

Try This Now (60 seconds, no prep): Say it aloud three times with a neighbor: "Thanks, I'll call you back at the number I already have." It feels odd the first time. That is why we practice it before we need it.

I

01

The big idea

Social engineering is manipulating a person into doing something that helps an attacker: giving a password or a code, sending money, opening a door, installing something. It works because it targets normal human instincts: helpfulness, respect for authority, fear, and trust.

The defense is not a special talent. It is **a routine that works even when you are rushed and upset:**

FIELD NOTE

No. 1

Hang up. Look up. Call back.

Hang up on the unexpected request. Look up the real number or address yourself from a source you trust (the back of your card, the official website you typed or bookmarked, the school office directory). Call back, or ask in person. And for your closest people, agree on a **family code word** now, before you need it.

This demo is built around **verification role-plays**. The learners practice being the person who is *receiving* the request. They are never asked to practice manipulating others.

02

What a teacher should know (plain language)

2.1 WHY IT WORKS: SEVEN PRESSURE LEVERS

PSYCHOLOGIST ROBERT CIALDINI DESCRIBED persuasion principles that scammers misuse: **authority, scarcity/urgency, social proof, liking, reciprocity and commitment** (and later "unity") [VERIFY the list and any 2021 edition addition]. We use plain names:

LEVER	WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE	DEFENSE
Authority	"I'm from the bank / police / your principal."	Titles are easy to claim. Verify through a known route.
Urgency	"You must act in the next ten minutes."	Real emergencies still allow a callback. Slow down on purpose.
Fear	"You're in trouble / your account is hacked."	Fear makes us skip checking. Breathe, then check.
Liking / familiarity	"Hey, it's me, I got a new number."	Familiar can be faked. Check another way.
Reward	"You won," "Free gift."	If you did not enter, you did not win.
Helpfulness	"Can you hold the door / lend your login?"	Being kind and being careful can coexist: "Sorry, I can't, let me get the office."
Secrecy	"Don't tell anyone."	Secrecy is the red flag. Tell a trusted adult.

2.2 PRETEXTING

A **pretext** is a made-up story that makes a request seem normal. Real-world examples include the fake "bank fraud department" call, the "grandchild in jail" call, the "tech support" call, and the "I'm new here, can you hold the door?" visitor. We do not rehearse **writing** pretexts. We teach to notice that **a story that arrives with pressure and a request for a secret is a pattern.**

2.3 THE CALLBACK RULE (DONE PROPERLY)

1. **Do not use contact details supplied by the person.** Use ones you already know are real.
2. **Caller ID can be faked.** The name or number on your screen is not proof.
3. Hang up and **dial yourself.** For landline calls, wait or use another line, because some old systems may keep a call open [VERIFY].
4. If a "boss", "relative" or "teacher" sends an odd request by text or email, verify **in person or by calling a known number.**
5. If it was truly urgent, the real person will understand the delay. A criminal will pressure you not to check.

2.4 THE FAMILY CODE WORD (AND ITS LIMITS)

A **code word** (or short phrase) that the family agrees on **in person** and uses to confirm that a person who calls or messages in an emergency is really them. It became especially valuable now that AI can imitate voices from short audio clips (Demo 12).

Good practice:

- Choose it **together, offline.** Do not text it, do not post it, do not use it on social media.
- Make it **random and unguessable:** two or three unrelated words (an illustration only: "purple-ladder-soup"; do not use this one), not a pet's name, birthday or street. (Demo 1 logic applies.)
- **Rehearse it** once or twice so everyone remembers it, and practice what to say when someone calls: "What's our code word?"
- **Only use it** for emergencies that involve money, pickup, personal details or secrecy.
- **Change it** if it has been used in front of others, spoken in a way someone could overhear, or if it has leaked.
- Children should know it and know that a trusted adult would **never be upset** if a child asks for it.
- **Limits:** a code word helps only if someone remembers to ask for it. Still use the callback rule. If the caller says "I forgot," treat that as unverified and use the callback.



2.5 PHYSICAL SOCIAL ENGINEERING (SCHOOL-RELEVANT)

- **Tailgating:** someone follows you through a secured door. Polite response: "Please check in at the office; I'll show you where it is."
- **Shoulder surfing:** someone watches you type a PIN. Shield your input.
- **Impersonation by uniform or clipboard:** anyone claiming to be "district staff" or "a repair person" is verified by the office.
- Do not teach any method for bypassing locks or entry controls. Teach only the response: **don't hold secured doors; direct to the office.**

2.6 WHAT IF IT WORKED?

If you shared a code, clicked, paid or let someone in, the quickest and bravest step is to **tell right away**. Banks can sometimes freeze payments, accounts can be secured, and schools can react. Fast and honest beats perfect. **It is never the person's fault.** Scammers are professionals who rehearse. (In 2025 consumers reported losing \$3.5 billion to imposter scams, and nearly one in three fraud reports were imposter scams [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: ftc.gov press release, June 2026].)

2.7 COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

MYTH	BETTER UNDERSTANDING
"Only gullible people fall for it."	It works on smart, careful people when they are rushed or scared.
"Hanging up is rude."	A polite firm script is respected; real organizations expect callbacks.
"The caller ID matched."	Caller ID can be faked.
"I can always tell a scammer by their voice or accent."	No. AI voices and polished scripts defeat this. Use process, not instinct.
"A code word will save us."	It is one layer; combine it with the callback rule.

03 Materials (zero to low cost)

- The **Reader cards** (8 scenarios), **Coach scorecard** and **Polite Script cards** are printed on the student handout pages. Copy and cut them; they contain no answers. Index cards for code word design (fake words only), a timer, and a prop phone (or a drawn one).

04 Role-play design rules (read before you run it)

1. **Roles:** *Receiver* (practices the defense), *Reader* (reads the printed Caller card word for word; improvisation is not allowed), and *Coach* (scores with the checklist). Rotate so each student is Receiver once.
2. **No improvised manipulation.** The Reader only reads the printed card. The point is to practice responses, not to practice pressure on others.
3. **No real organizations or real people.** All names are fictional: "Brightway Bank", "Parcel Pal", "Principal Reyes".
4. **No practice on real people outside class** (no "trick your parents" homework). The take-home task is to *create* the family code word.
5. **Stop rule:** any student who feels uncomfortable can say "pause" and the scene ends without explanation.

The **Coach scorecard** (Pause, No secrets, Callback, Polite and firm, Tell) is on the student handout.

05 Scenario Cards (Caller lines are fictional and are to be read exactly)

THE EIGHT READER CARDS are on the student handout: 1 Bank call, 2 Relative in trouble, 3 Game friend, 4 Tech support, 5 Delivery visitor at school door, 6 Principal text, 7 Prize call, 8 Voice clone voicemail. The suggested best response to each is on the teacher answer page. **Cards 2 and 8 are optional for grades 3-5 and for any group where a student may find them close to home.**

06 Part A: Teachers do it first (about 25 minutes)

1. **Cold read (5 min).** Read the eight cards silently. Which would trick you if you were tired? Which lever is being pulled?
2. **Role-play (12 min).** In trios (Receiver, Reader, Coach) play three cards, scoring with the Coach scorecard; each person is Receiver once. Try Cards 2 and 8 for the code word moment.
3. **Code word design (5 min).** Build a sample family code word (not your real one) using the rules in 2.4 and check it is not guessable.
4. **Reflect (3 min).** Which part felt hardest (often: not caving in to politeness)? Which phrase will you carry?

07 Part B: Teaching it

15-MINUTE VERSION

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
0-2	Hook and the rule: Hang up. Look up. Call back.
2-4	Model: teacher plays Receiver with a student Reader on Card 1.
4-11	Trios role-play Cards 1, 5 and 7 (three rounds of two minutes with rotation).
11-14	Family code word: each student writes a practice code word on an index card (fake, then discard).
14-15	Exit slip: "My callback line is..."

45-MINUTE VERSION

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
0-5	Hook, levers (authority, urgency, fear), the callback rule.
5-10	Model with a volunteer, narrating thinking aloud.
10-30	Trios rotate through Cards 1-8 (two to three minutes each), with Coach scoring. Teacher floats and listens.
30-38	Code word lab: groups design a code word using the guidelines; pass to another group to critique ("Is it guessable? Is it posted anywhere?"). Discuss physical social engineering (door, tailgating).
38-43	Debrief the hardest card, polite scripts, "what if it worked?"
43-45	Exit ticket and take-home family card.

08 Teacher script

Hook (2 minutes). "I'm going to read you something and I want you to notice what it makes you feel: 'Your account is in danger! You need to act in five minutes!' Did your heart jump a little? That's your hackles. Scammers aim at that feeling because a rushed brain doesn't check. Today we practice a three-step move that works even when you're rushed: Hang up. Look up. Call back."

Model. "Here is a call: 'I'm from the bank, read me the code.' My thought: unexpected, urgent, asks for a secret. Hackles up. I say: 'Thanks, I'll call you back at the number on my card.' I hang up. I look up the real number. I call. Notice, I was polite. I didn't need to win an argument."

After the role-plays. "Which card was hardest? Why? What lever was pulled? If you got stuck, you have a script card. You don't have to be clever. You have to be consistent."

Code word moment. "A family code word is a lock made of words. We make it together, in person, and we don't post it. If someone calls and says they're your cousin in trouble, you ask: 'What's our code word?'"

Close. "You are never in trouble for checking. Adults will thank you. If someone already tricked you, or you gave out a code, it's not your fault. Tell a trusted adult right away."

09 Kid-friendly analogies by band

BAND	ANALOGY AND ACTIVITY
K-2	The grown-up check. "If someone asks for a secret or says 'don't tell', I say 'I need to check with my grown-up.'" Practice with puppets (Hackle hand signals: Hackles Up, Pause Palm, Tell Wave). No scary scenarios; use "a stranger asks for your password" in gentle form.
3-5	The doorbell rule, but for phones. You don't open the door for anyone who says "open up" without checking. Use scenario cards 1, 3, 5, 7 with Reader lines. Practice Polite Script cards. Make a family code word card to take home.
6-8	Levers and scripts. Name the lever on each card, choose the script, role-play all cards. Discuss: why do scammers choose secrecy? Why is politeness not the same as compliance?
9-12	Pretext analysis and organizational controls. Compare personal defenses (callback, code word) with organizational controls (two-person rule for payments, verified channels, clear reporting). Discuss AI voice cloning, deepfake video calls (Demo 12), and "verify then trust."

10 Discussion questions

1. Which lever pulled hardest on you, urgency, authority or fear? Why?
2. Why is hanging up not rude, and why does "don't tell anyone" make a request more suspicious?
3. What makes a good family code word? What makes a bad one?
4. (9-12) Why do organizations use a "two-person rule" for money? How does it protect individuals from being the single point of failure?

11 Level-up challenge

- **The Family Check Plan.** Students design a family verification plan on paper (code word rules, who to call, where the trusted numbers live, what to do if someone gets tricked) and share it with a family member as a conversation, not a test.
- **Lever mapping.** Annotate five fictional scripts with the lever(s) used (annotate only; do not write new scripts).

12 Safety and ethics notes (defense only)

- **Do not teach scripts, techniques or tricks to manipulate people.** Readers read pre-written cards; no free improvisation of persuasion; no "make the Receiver cave" competition.
- **Do not practice on real people.** No attempts to "test" parents, friends or staff. Phishing or social engineering simulations on real people require formal organizational policy and consent, and are not part of this demo.
- **No physical-bypass instruction.** Do not demonstrate how to defeat locks, badges, doors or entry procedures. Teach only responses (direct to the office).
- **Sensitive content.** Cards 2 and 8 may remind some students of real family stress or fear. Allow opting out of scenes. Never ask students to share family emergency details.
- **Disclosures.** Some students may disclose that someone has pressured them, asked for secrets or images, or scared them. Follow the school's reporting process; see the box in the Index and your Teacher Guide. Never promise secrecy.
- Avoid shame language. "It was a clever trick" is better than "you should have known".

13 Assessment idea

- **Role-play rubric (Coach scorecard).** Observe each student once as Receiver. 4 or 5 checks = secure; 3 = developing; fewer = re-teach.
- **Exit ticket.** "Write your callback sentence and one place you would find the real number."

14 Sources and [VERIFY] list

- FTC press release, "FTC Data Show People Reported Losing \$3.5 Billion to Imposter Scams in 2025" [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]; the Consumer Sentinel Data Book itself was not opened.
- FBI IC3 annual reports [2025 report VERIFIED 2026-10-05]; FBI public service announcements on "grandparent" scams and AI voice cloning, including the advice to create a family code word [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: FBI IC3 PSA241203 (December 2024): "Create a secret word or phrase with your family to verify their identity"].
- Robert Cialdini, "Influence" (principles of persuasion) [edition and the later "unity" principle were not checked].
- CISA "Avoiding Social Engineering and Phishing Attacks" [page exists: VERIFIED 2026-10-05: cisa.gov].

- UK NCSC guidance on social engineering [not checked].

SECTION

2

2

Student Handout: Hang Up. Look Up. Call Back.

Name: _____

The rule

1. **Hang up** on an unexpected request.
2. **Look up** the real number yourself (card, official site, school directory).
3. **Call back** or ask in person.

Pressure levers: match the line to the lever

WRITE THE LETTER OF the lever. Levers: A Urgency, B Authority, C Reward, D Fear.

1. "I'm from the bank." ____
2. "You have ten minutes!" ____
3. "You won a prize!" ____
4. "You're in trouble!" ____

My callback script

"Thanks, I'll call you back at the number I already have."

My trusted adults: _____

Family code word checklist (don't write the real word here!)

- ☐ We chose it **together, in person**
- ☐ It's **random** (not a pet, birthday or street)
- ☐ We never post or text it
- ☐ We practiced it
- ☐ We change it if it leaks

Practice

A TEXT SAYS: "IT'S me, I lost my phone, can you send a code?" What do I do?

Circle: **Reply with the code / Call them on their known number / Ask my adult**

Remember

- Hanging up is not rude. Checking is smart.
- Secrecy is a red flag. Tell a trusted adult.
- If someone tricked you, **it is not your fault**. Tell right away.
- Never practice tricks on real people.

Role-Play Cards (Reader, Coach and Receiver sheet)

ALL NAMES ARE MADE up. The Reader reads the card exactly as printed and does not add or improvise anything. Anyone can say "pause" to stop a scene. Cards 2 and 8 are optional.

Reader cards

CARD	SETTING	READER'S PRINTED LINE
1 Bank	Phone call	"This is Brightway Bank's fraud department. Someone is trying to use your card. To protect you, please read me the code we just texted."
2 Relative in trouble	Phone call, voice sounds like a relative	"It's me, I'm in trouble, don't tell Mom, I need you to send money."
3 Game friend	In-game chat	"My account got banned, can I borrow yours for a day? I'll give you rare items."
4 Tech support	Pop-up and phone	"Your computer is infected. Install this program so I can fix it."
5 Delivery visitor	At school door	"I'm with the district, I'm in a hurry, can you hold the door?"
6 Principal text	Text message	"This is Principal Reyes. Quick favor: buy gift cards for me and send photos of the codes. Keep it quiet."
7 Prize	Phone call	"You've won a gift card! We just need a small fee and your card number."
8 Voice clone	Voicemail from "a parent"	"Hi, it's Dad. My phone's broken, text me the password to the family account."

Coach scorecard (check each yes)

- ☐ Pause: did the Receiver take a breath and slow down?
- ☐ No secrets: did they refuse to share a code, password or personal data?
- ☐ Callback: did they say they would verify with a number or person they already know?
- ☐ Polite and firm: did they avoid insults and avoid giving in?
- ☐ Tell: did they say they would tell a trusted adult?

Polite Script cards (practice aloud)

1. "Thanks, I'll call you back at the number I already have."
2. "I'm not allowed to share that. I'll check with my grown-up."
3. "Our family has a rule: we always use our code word."
4. "I'd like to speak with them in person."
5. "I'm going to hang up now and check."
6. "That sounds like a tricky situation; let me tell my teacher."

End of student handout.

TEACHER COPY ONLY:

Answers for Demo 8 (do not distribute to students)

FIELD NOTE

No. 2

WARNING: Teacher page. Remove before copying. The student handout ends on the page before this one. Print the handout pages only, or detach this page first. Do not post it, project it or send it home.

Lever match: 1 B (authority), 2 A (urgency), 3 C (reward), 4 D (fear).

Practice: call them on their known number, and ask an adult.

Suggested best responses to the Reader cards

CARD	BEST RESPONSE
1 Bank	"I never read codes. I'll call the number on the back of my card."
2 Relative in trouble	"What's our family code word?" If it does not match: hang up, call them on their known number, tell a trusted adult.
3 Game friend	"No, I don't share my account. I'm telling my parent."
4 Tech support	Close it, don't call, tell an adult.
5 Delivery visitor	"Please check at the office. I'll show you where it is."
6 Principal text	"I'll check with you in person." Verify at the office; tell a trusted adult.
7 Prize	"No thanks. If I won, I'll check on the official website." Hang up.
8 Voice clone	Check by calling the known number, use the family code word, tell the other parent.

Levers on the cards: 1 authority and urgency; 2 fear, liking and secrecy; 3 liking and reward; 4 fear and authority; 5 helpfulness and urgency; 6 authority and secrecy; 7 reward; 8 liking and urgency.

Scoring: 4 or 5 Coach checks = secure; 3 = developing; fewer = re-teach.

Assessment transfer idea: a "coach" texts asking for a team password; students name the lever and write the verification step.